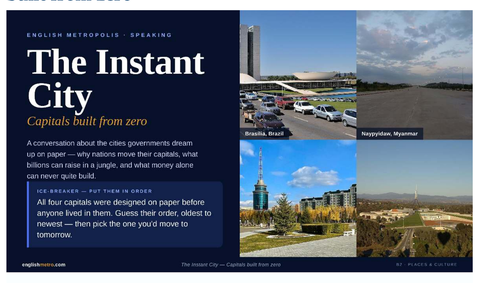
GEN-B2-PLACES 01 - The Instant City ? Capitals built from zero



Let's talk

B2 · Warm-up

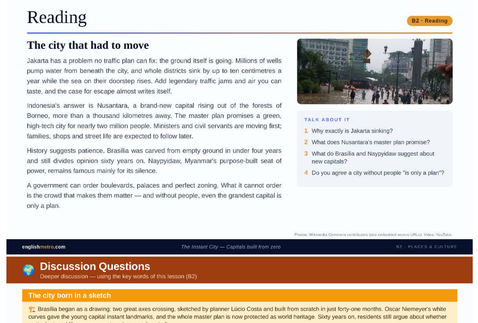
1. What's the newest district in your city like?
2. Do you prefer old towns or modern centres?
3. Is your city well planned or happily chaotic?
4. What makes a city feel alive?
5. Would you move to a brand-new city?

Speak freely — there are no wrong answers here.

Discussion

B2 · Speaking

1. Why might a country build a brand-new capital instead of repairing the one it has?
2. Brasília went up in under four years. What can that speed create — and what can't it?
3. Naypyidaw has twenty-lane roads and little traffic. Why do governments love giant showcases?
4. Is it fair to spend billions on a new capital while ordinary towns wait for basics?
5. Jakarta sinks because millions of wells pump its groundwater. Who should have stopped that?
6. Can a city planned on paper ever feel like home? What would it need first?
7. Should a capital showcase the nation's power, or its everyday life?
8. If Poland decided to build a new capital from scratch, where should it go?



If people would be living there for lots of years

Key words

B2 · Vocabulary

WORD / PHRASE	PRONUNCIATION	POLSKI	EXAMPLE
from scratch	/frɒm skrætʃ/	od zera	*Nusantara is being built from scratch in the Borneo jungle.*
a master plan	/ə ˈmɑːstə plæn/	plan generalny	*The master plan fixed the position of every ministry and park.*
to relocate	/ˌriːləʊˈkeɪt/	przenieść (się)	*Indonesia is relocating its government 1,200 kilometres away.*
overcrowded	/ˌəʊvəˈkraʊdɪd/	przeludniony	*Jakarta grew overcrowded long before anyone agreed on a solution.*
to sink	/sɪŋk/	tonąć, zapadać się	*Parts of the old capital sink several centimetres every year.*
a landmark	/ˈlændmɑːk/	charakterystyczny obiekt	*Niemeyer's cathedral became the young city's first landmark.*
soulless	/ˈsəʊllɪs/	bezduszny	*Critics call the huge empty boulevards impressive but soulless.*

Watch & talk

B2 · Listening

▶ youtube.com/watch?v=fWENuDSu0SQ - "Indonesia's $33B Capital Relocation Plan" (WSJ) · watch ~8 min

WHILE YOU WATCH

1. Why has Jakarta become so hard to keep as a capital?
2. What is Nusantara supposed to offer that Jakarta can't?
3. What doubts and risks does the report raise?

After watching: would you bet on Nusantara succeeding? Give one reason each way.

(Petrol / Petroleum / Oil) refineries

Bomb (pronunciation Bom)
Bomber

It's a good place

Reading

B2 · Reading

The city that had to move

Jakarta has a problem no traffic plan can fix: the ground itself is going. Millions of wells pump water from beneath the city, and whole districts sink by up to ten centimetres a year while the sea on their doorstep rises. Add legendary traffic jams and air you can taste, and the case for escape almost writes itself.

Indonesia's answer is Nusantara, a brand-new capital rising out of the forests of Borneo, more than a thousand kilometres away. The master plan promises a green, high-tech city for nearly two million people. Ministers and civil servants are moving first; families, shops and street life are expected to follow later.

History suggests patience. Brasília was carved from empty ground in under four years and still divides opinion sixty years on. Naypyidaw, Myanmar's purpose-built seat of power, remains famous mainly for its silence.

A government can order boulevards, palaces and perfect zoning. What it cannot order is the crowd that makes them matter — and without people, even the grandest capital is only a plan.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. Why exactly is Jakarta sinking?
2. What does Nusantara's master plan promise?
3. What do Brasília and Naypyidaw suggest about new capitals?
4. Do you agree a city without people "is only a plan"?

Photos: Wikimedia Commons contributors (see embedded source URLs). Video: YouTube.

Discussion Questions

Deeper discussion — using the key words of this lesson (B2)

The city born in a sketch

🏗 Brasília began as a drawing: two great axes crossing, sketched by planner Lúcio Costa and built from scratch in just forty-one months. Oscar Niemeyer's white curves gave the young capital instant landmarks, and the whole master plan is now protected as world heritage. Sixty years on, residents still argue about whether a city designed like a monument works as a place to live.

📖 Read more — Wikipedia

1. Could you love a city that is younger than your grandparents?
2. Should a capital be a work of art, a machine, or both?
3. What ages faster: buildings or the ideas behind them?
4. Would you trust one architect with a whole city?

The empty boulevards

🛣 Naypyidaw has twenty-lane highways, golf courses and room for millions — and famously little traffic. Myanmar's generals relocated their capital there almost overnight in 2005, far from the crowds of Yangon. Visitors describe a showcase city that feels strangely soulless: everything a capital needs, except the bustle that makes one real.

📖 Read more — Wikipedia

5. Why might leaders prefer a capital without crowds?
6. Is a quiet capital a failure, or exactly what its builders wanted?
7. Can prestige projects ever be worth their price tag?
8. Should embassies and airlines be forced to follow the government there?

Discussion Questions

Deeper discussion — continued

Moving day for a nation

🚚 Overcrowded, gridlocked and slowly sinking, Jakarta is handing its crown to Nusantara, a forest capital being built from scratch on Borneo. Supporters call it a fresh start for a nation of seventeen thousand islands; critics point to displaced communities, felled rainforest and a thirty-three-billion-dollar bill. Moving day has already begun.

📖 Read more — Wikipedia

9. Would you volunteer to be a new city's first resident?
10. What does a capital owe the city it leaves behind?
11. Is a fresh start worth thirty-three billion dollars?
12. Who should move first: politicians, businesses or families?

Why capitals move

📝 Purpose-built capitals are older than they look: Washington was a compromise between rival states, Canberra settled a duel between Sydney and Melbourne, and Kazakhstan relocated to windswept Astana partly to anchor its north. A new capital is never just a construction project — it redraws the map of power, which is exactly why nations keep building them.

📖 Read more — Wikipedia

13. What would moving the capital change for ordinary people?
14. Should a capital sit in the country's centre, or its biggest city?
15. Which city in your country could play the capital instead?
16. If you could relocate any institution, which would it be?

🎯 Speaking Accuracy Workout
First Impressions — say it right, and right at speed

These four patterns are the ones worth tightening. The ideas are already there in English — we are just sharpening the surface. **Tip:** a half-second pause before the place/time word, the noun, or the verb fixes most of it. *Answers are on the next page.*

A — Prepositions: in / on / at / by (correct each)

1. I always feel nervous **at** the start of a presentation.
2. We have the client meeting **on** Monday morning.
3. She is very good **at** speaking to a big audience.
4. He shook my hand and looked me in the eyes with confidence.
5. I was so nervous that I kept fidgeting with my pen during the talk.
6. Please put your slides in the screen before we begin.

⏱ B — Third-person -s under speed (TIMED — read all 10 aloud in 40 seconds)

Every verb after *he / she / it / one person* must keep its **-s**. Drop one and the clock restarts.

1. A confident speaker scans the whole room before he starts.
2. She adjusts the microphone and then takes a slow breath.
3. Good posture makes a nervous presenter look calm.
4. The audience notices when a speaker fidgets with his notes.
5. A strong opening line grabs the room in seconds.
6. Body language often says more than the slides do.
7. One distracting mannerism pulls attention away from the message.
8. A great presenter tells a story and the room listens.
9. Eye contact builds trust faster than any slide.
10. She takes charge of the meeting the moment she stands up.

C — Articles: a / the (fix it)

1. I have to give presentation to the board tomorrow.
2. He is speaker at the conference.
3. First impression is very important in business.
4. She made great impression on the client.
5. Most difficult part is the opening line.
6. Good body language builds trust with whole room.

D — Polish calques (say the natural English version)

1. Could you explain me this slide?
2. It's depends on the audience.
3. In last week I gave three presentations.
4. I think so first impressions matter a lot.
5. The more important is to stay calm.
6. Could you repeat one more, please?

⏱ E — Rapid-fire mix (TIMED — 60 seconds, 8 sentences)

Read each wrong sentence and immediately say the correct one. These combine preposition + article + -s — accuracy AT speed, because that is exactly when the slips happen.

1. In the start I am always nervous and I forget my first line.
2. He don't make eye contact and audience lose interest.
3. In last meeting she give presentation on the train topic.
4. Could you explain me this in Monday?
5. Good presenter scan the room and speak slowly.
6. It's depends on first impression.
7. I am good in public speaking and I practise every day.
8. The more important is to engage the audience.

English Line · 05 Jul 2026

Or maybe it will have an influence on my confidence

Probably it's because I'm not using English everyday

Word: *eerie* experience
Translation: niepokojące, przyprawiające o dreszcze przeżycie
Explanation: A strange and slightly frightening experience that makes you feel uncomfortable.
Example sentences:
English 1: Walking through the empty hotel at night was an eerie experience.
Polish 1: Spacer po pustym hotelu w nocy był niepokojącym przeżyciem.
English 2: Hearing footsteps in the abandoned building was an eerie experience.
Polish 2: Usłyszenie kroków w opuszczonym budynku było przeżyciem przyprawiającym o dreszcze.
English 3: It was an eerie experience to see the streets completely deserted.
Polish 3: Widok zupełnie pustych ulic był bardzo niepokojącym przeżyciem.

But it's not near the centre

Well designed for living and **leisure**

Word: leisure
Translation: czas wolny; wypoczynek; rekreacja
Explanation: Time when you are not working and can relax or enjoy activities. In this context, it refers to relaxation and recreational use.
Example sentences:
English 1: The development is well designed for both living and leisure.
Polish 1: Osiedle zostało dobrze zaprojektowane zarówno do codziennego życia, jak i wypoczynku.
English 2: The hotel offers plenty of facilities for leisure and relaxation.
Polish 2: Hotel oferuje wiele udogodnień do wypoczynku i relaksu.
English 3: This area is ideal for work, family life, and leisure.
Polish 3: Ta okolica świetnie nadaje się do pracy, życia rodzinnego i spędzania wolnego czasu.

And having the best times of their lives

They closed forest**s**

People remembered that they had to run in masks

Maybe a little bit more to the west

I don't know where the safest place would be

Sidewalks (USA) / pavement (UK)

I think there are lots of one way roads

When I had an appointment at the bank

I think everything is easily **accessible**
~~communicate~~ there (collocations)

Skysc**r**apers (pronunciation)

Everything was perfect**ly** planned

Word: district
Translation: dzielnica
Explanation: A particular area of a city or town, often with its own character or purpose.
Example sentences:
English 1: She lives in a quiet district near the city centre.
Polish 1: Mieszka w spokojnej dzielnicy niedaleko centrum miasta.
English 2: This district is famous for its cafés and art galleries.
Polish 2: Ta dzielnica słynie z kawiarni i galerii sztuki.
English 3: A new business district is being built by the river.
Polish 3: Nad rzeką powstaje nowa dzielnica biznesowa.

Rustic

Well-kept buildings

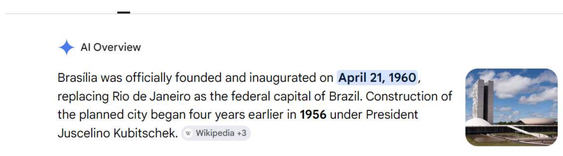
Word: well-kept
Translation: zadbany, dobrze utrzymany
Explanation: Clean, tidy, and in good condition because someone takes care of it.
Example sentences:
English 1: The neighbourhood is full of well-kept buildings.
Polish 1: W tej dzielnicy jest wiele zadbanych budynków.
English 2: They live in a well-kept old house.
Polish 2: Mieszkają w zadbanym starym domu.
English 3: The park is clean and well-kept.
Polish 3: Park jest czysty i dobrze utrzymany.

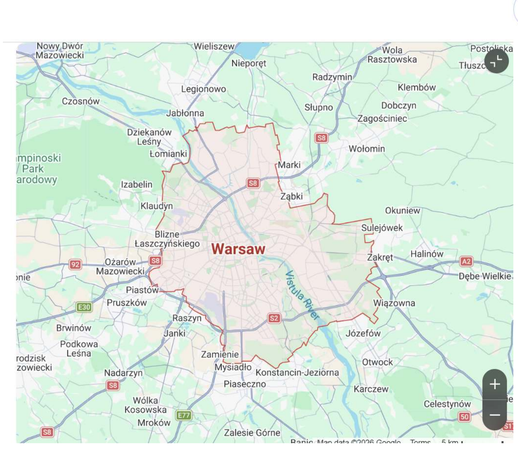
In Włoche
I live **on** Jasielska Street

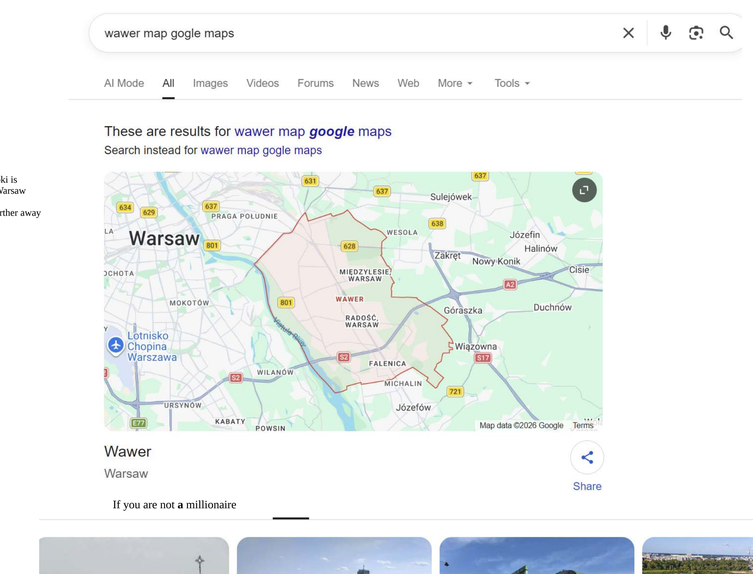
(Petrol / Petroleum / Oil) refineries

Bomb (pronunciation Bom)
Bomber

It's **a** good place



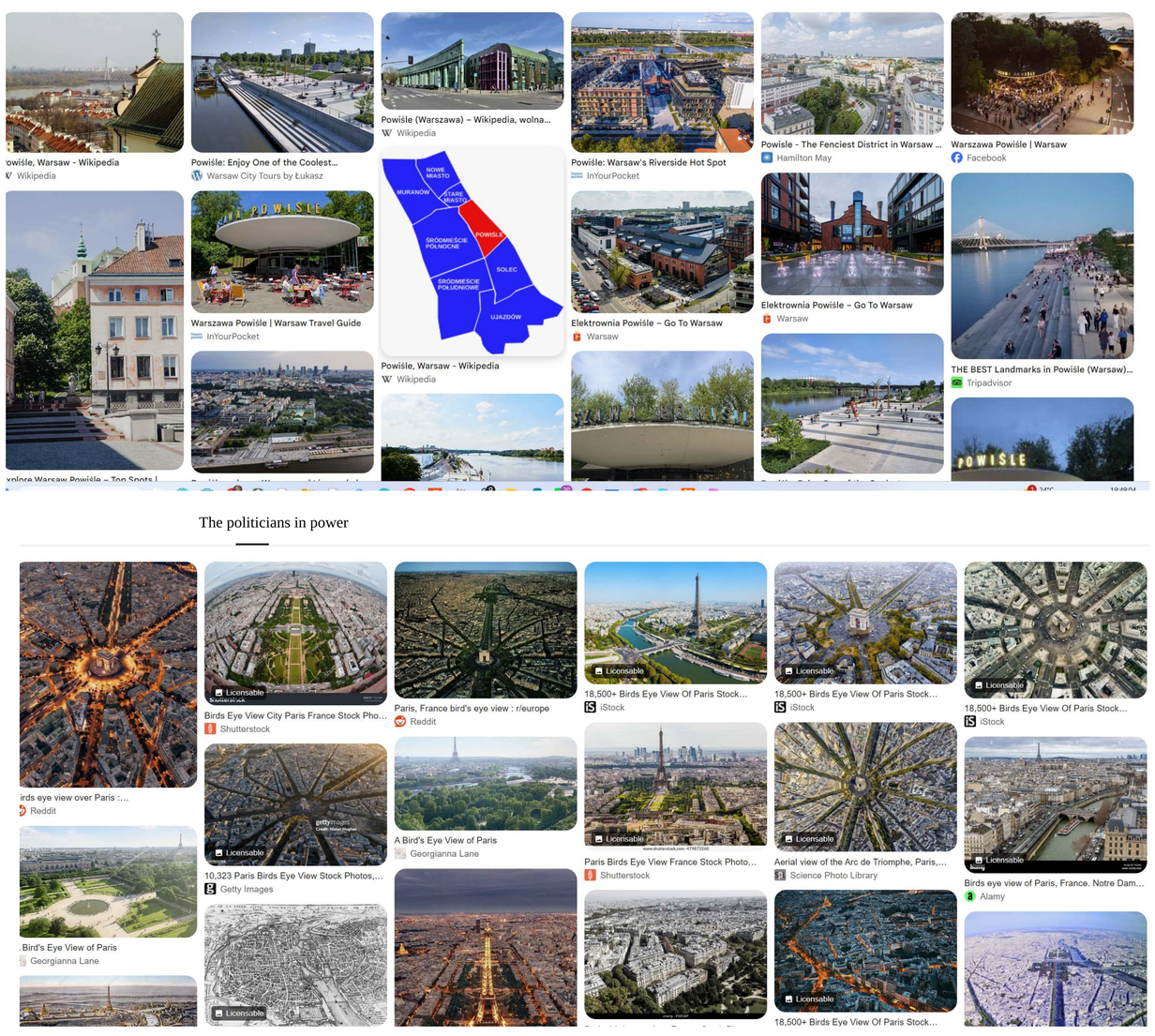




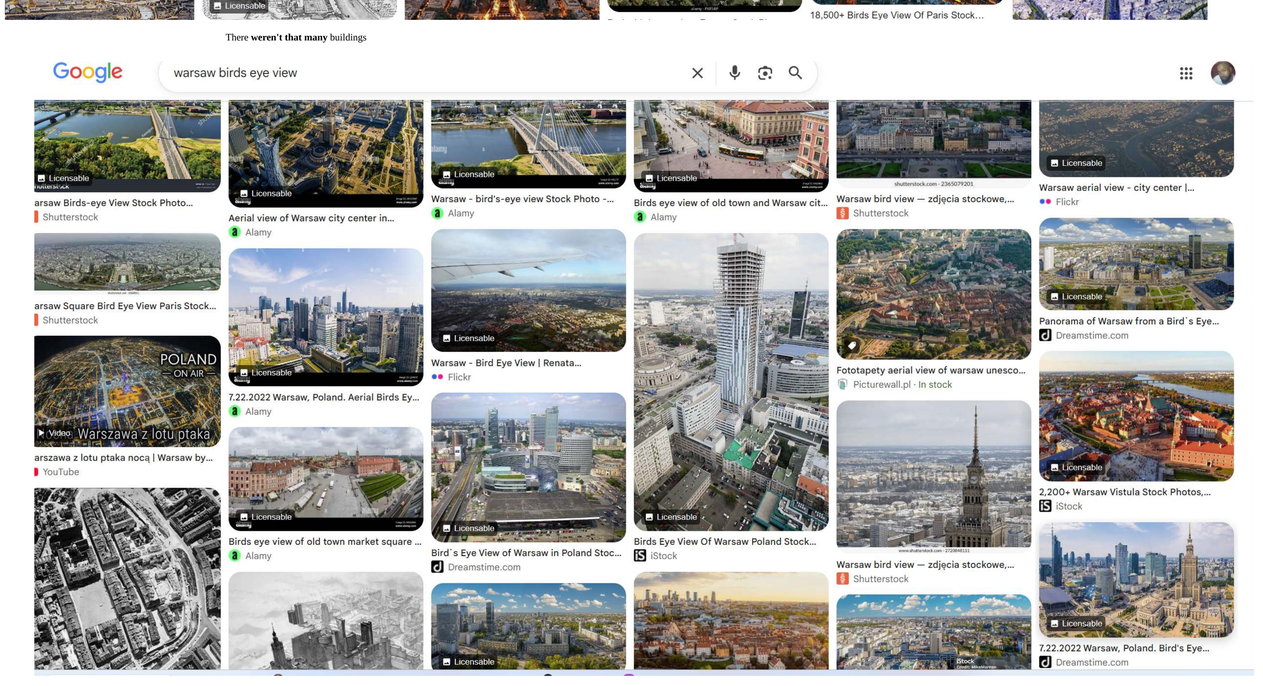
I'm not sure if zompki is considered part of Warsaw

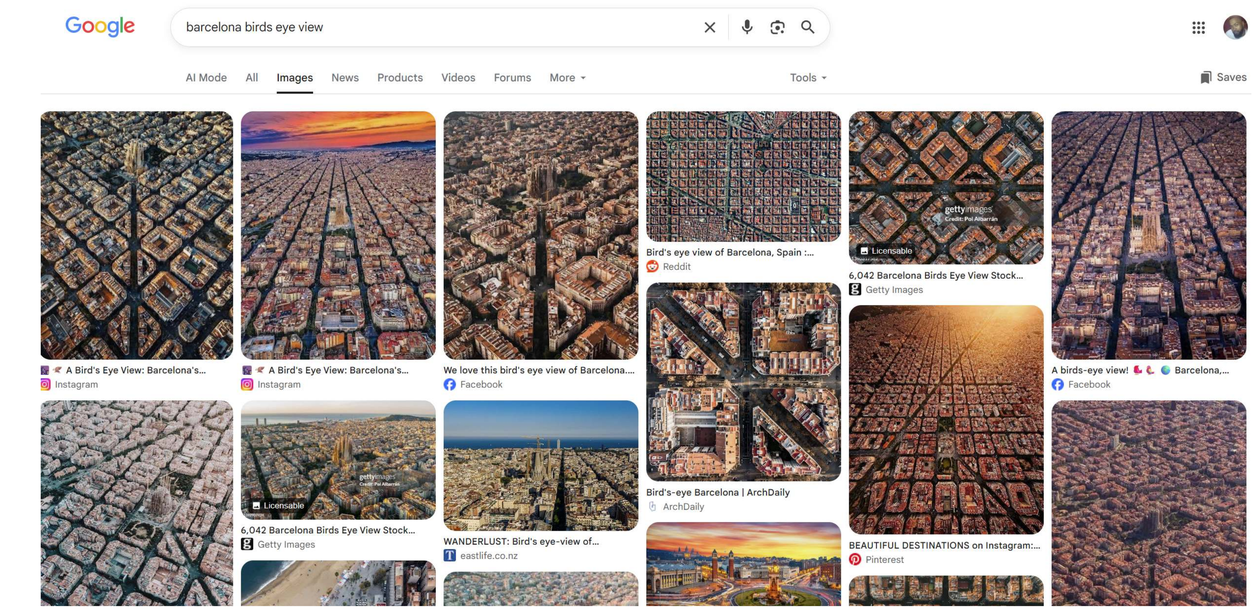
Zompki is a little further away than praga południe

If you are not **a** millionaire



The politicians in power





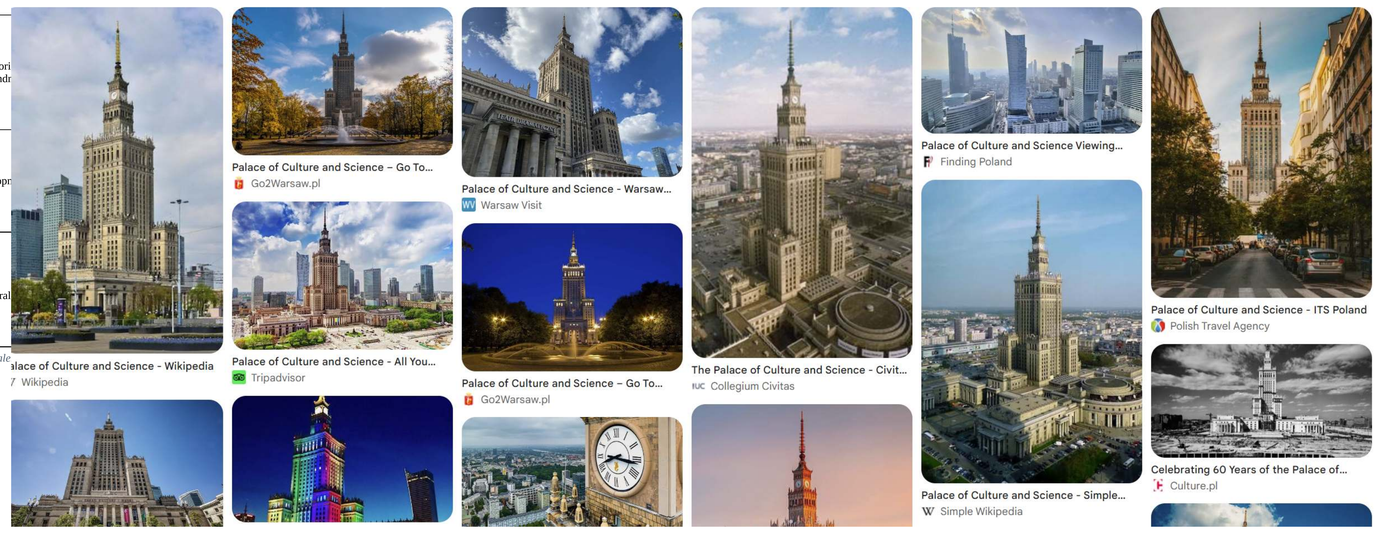
Probably they will do something to prevent it from sinking

Lesson Keywords ? Detailed Table

GEN-B2-PLACES-01: The Instant City ? Capitals built from zero

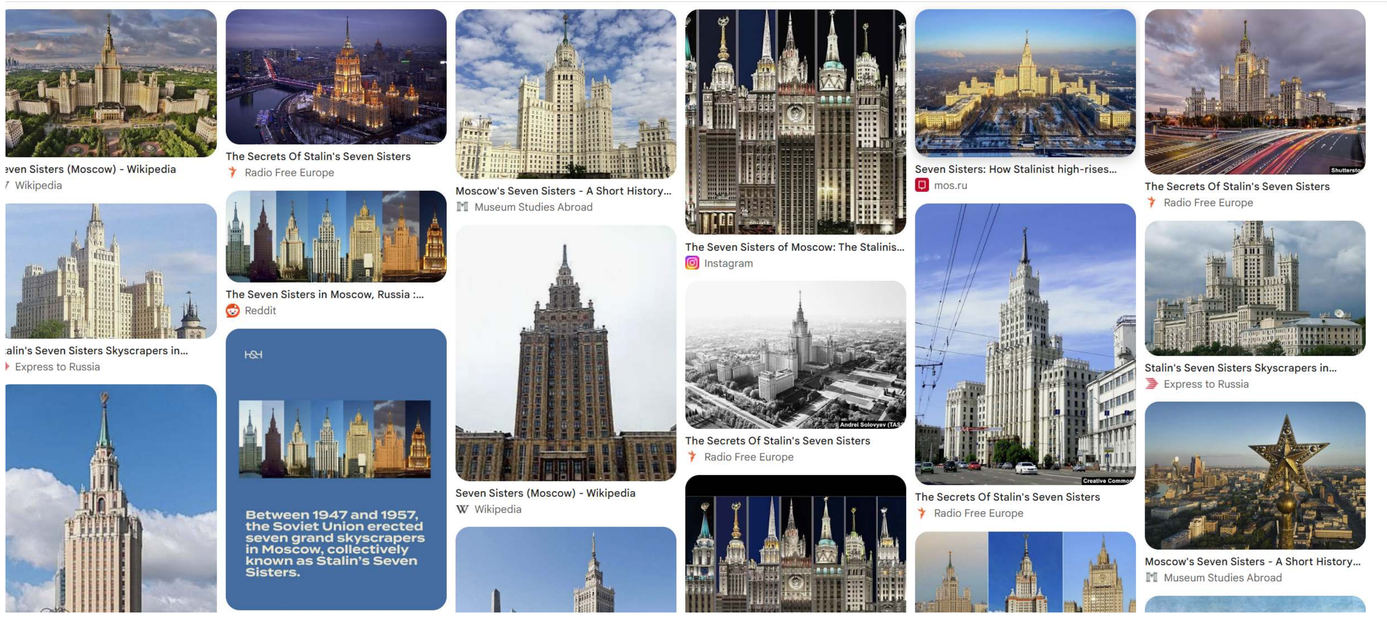
No.	Keyword / Phrase	IPA	Polish translation	Definition (EN)	Definition (PL)	Common collocations	Example (EN)	Example (PL)	Usage note / common mistake
1	**from scratch**	/fr?m skr?t?/	od podstaw; od zera	From the beginning, without using something that already exists.	Od samego pocz?tku, bez korzystania z czego?, co ju? istnieje.	build/design/start from scratch	Bras?lia was designed from scratch as Brazil?s new capital.	Bras?lia została zaprojektowana od podstaw jako nowa stolica Brazylii.	Use ?from scratch?, not ?from the scratch?.
2	**a master plan**	/? ? m??.st? pl?n/	plan generalny; kompleksowy plan zagospodarowania	A detailed long-term plan for developing a city, site or major project.	Szczeg??owy d? ugoterminowy plan rozwoju miasta, terenu lub du?ego projektu.	draw up/follow/revise a master plan; urban master plan	The master plan separated government buildings from residential districts.	Plan generalny oddziela? budynki rz? dowe od dzielnic mieszkalnych.	?Master plan? is countable: a master plan / the master plan.
3	**to relocate**	/? ri?.l??? ke?t/	przenie??; przesiedli?; przenie?? si?	To move a person, organisation or place of activity to a new location.	Przenie?? osob?, organizacj? lub dzia? alno?? do nowej lokalizacji.	relocate the capital/headquarters/residents; relocate to	Indonesia decided to relocate its capital from Jakarta to Nusantara.	Indonezja zdecydowa?a si? przenie?? stolic? z D? akarty do Nusantary.	Transitive or intransitive: relocate the office; the office relocated.
4	**overcrowded**	/???.v?? kra?.d? d/	przeludniony; nadmiernie zat? oczony	Containing more people than is comfortable, safe or practical.	Maj?cy wi?cej ludzi, ni? jest to wygodne, bezpieczne lub praktyczne.	overcrowded city/transport/housing; become overcrowded	The old capital had become overcrowded and increasingly difficult to manage.	Stara stolica sta?a si? przeludniona i coraz trudniejsza w zarz?dzaniu.	?Crowded? is busy/full; ? overcrowded? stresses that there are too many people.
5	**to *sink***	/s??k/	ton??; zapada? si?; obni?a? si?	To move down below a surface or gradually become lower.	Przesuwa? si? pod powierzchni? lub stopniowo si? obni?a?.	sink below sea level; sink into the ground; a sinking	Parts of Jakarta are	Cz??ci D? akarty zapadaj?	Irregular verb: sink?,
6	**a landmark**	/? ?l? nd.m?? k/	charakterystyczny punkt; wa?ny obiekt; zabytek	A well-known building or feature that is easy to recognise and may symbolise a place.	Znany budynek lub element, kt?ry ?atwo rozpozna? i kt?ry mo?e symbolizowa? dane miejsce.	famous/iconic/historic landmark; local landm			
7	**soulless**	/?s??l.l? s/	bezduszny; pozbawiony charakteru	Lacking warmth, personality or a sense of human life.	Pozbawiony ciep?a, osobowo?ci lub poczucia ludzkiego ? ycia.	soulless architecture/develop feel/look soulless			
8	**a showcase**	/? ????.ke? s/	wizyt?wka; pokaz mo?liwo?ci	Something designed to display the best qualities or achievements of a person, place or organisation.	Co? stworzonego po to, aby zaprezentowa? najlepsze cechy lub osi? gni?cia osoby, miejsca albo organizacji.	a showcase for/of; national/architectural			

British English pronunciation. Polish translations are contextual rather than one-to-one equivale



It's **a** really impressive building

I hope that they never **demolish** it



Word: demolish
Translation: zburzyć; wyburzyć
Explanation: To completely destroy a building or structure, usually in a planned way.
Example sentences:
English 1: I hope they never demolish this historic building.
Polish 1: Mam nadzieję, że nigdy nie wyburzą tego zabytkowego budynku.
English 2: The city plans to demolish the old factory next year.
Polish 2: Miasto planuje wyburzyć starą fabrykę w przyszłym roku.
English 3: Local residents protested against the decision to demolish the theatre.
Polish 3: Mieszkańcy protestowali przeciwko decyzji o zburzeniu teatru.

It's a little bit **of a** metaphor

Destroy
Disrobe

AI Overview

disrobe

/dɪsˈrəʊb/

Disrobe means to take off your clothes, undress, or remove formal garments. Cambridge Dictionary +1

Definition and Usage

- **Meaning:** To strip off clothing, robes, or ceremonial attire.
- **Context:** Often used in formal, medical, or theatrical settings (e.g., a patient preparing for an exam).
- **Synonyms:** Undress, strip, unclothe. Diki +2

If you need help with a **specific sentence**, **translation**, or **synonym usage**, just let me know!

AI Overview

robe

/rəʊb/

A **robe** is a long, loose piece of clothing, most commonly referring to either a casual **bathrobe** worn at home or a formal **ceremonial garment** worn by judges, graduates, or religious figures. Merriam-Webster +2

Types of Robes

- **Bathrobe / Dressing gown:** A soft, loose wrap worn before or after a bath or over pajamas.
- **Ceremonial robe:** A long outer garment showing a person's rank, job, or office (such as judge or academic robes).
- **Religious vestment:** Flowing garments worn by priests, monks, or other faith leaders during services. Merriam-Webster +6

Word Use as a Verb

- To **robe** means to dress, clothe, or put on a long outer garment. Merriam-Webster +1

Keyword Revision - Previous Lesson

Fill in the gaps. Use every word-bank item once. Change the form only where the sentence requires it.

Keyword Revision

1. ~~Starting a new role often involves a steep _____, especially when the systems and expectations are unfamiliar.~~
2. Repeated flooding was an _____ that Jakarta might face even greater pressure in the future.
3. When the same concern appears in several reports, it may be an _____ rather than an isolated incident.
4. The slow approval process became a _____ that delayed every stage of the project.
5. Building a capital from scratch involves a _____ between speed, cost and local character.
6. Before presenting to the board, she had _____ the research into three clear conclusions.
7. With a limited budget, planners must _____ essential transport and housing.
8. After residents criticised the design, the architects had _____ their original plan.
9. A person may have strong _____ but still experience a _____ in a new position.
10. When you have sound evidence, you should _____ and state your view clearly.
11. Her _____ connected what she observed, what it meant and what should happen next.
12. She chose _____ around practical benefits rather than personal preference.
13. Using real observations to support a clear judgement can help you _____.

Word Bank

- **professional narrative**
- **bottleneck**
- **to recalibrate**
- **competence**
- **early signal**
- **to turn experience into authority**
- **trade-off**
- **to prioritise**
- **confidence gap**
- **emerging pattern**
- **to synthesise**
- **to back yourself**
- **learning curve**
- **to frame a recommendation**

Follow-up

Choose 6 of the completed sentences and expand each one with a real example from your work or experience.

Fill in the gaps.

Keyword Revision

Revising answer vocabulary recorded in Aleksandra's previous lesson (L16).

1. ~~Even experienced specialists may feel a _____ when they begin leading a team. / **luka w pewności siebie**~~
2. Before making the final decision, we need _____ the information from all three reports. / **połączyć informacje w spójną całość**
3. ~~The security review became a major _____ and **delayed** the whole launch. / **wąskie gardło**~~
4. ~~Her _____ connected her skills, achievements and future goals into one clear story. / **narracja zawodowa**~~
5. ~~It is important _____ when you have strong evidence and a well-supported opinion. / **wierzyć w siebie**~~
6. ~~A sudden rise in complaints can be an _____ that the service needs attention. / **wczesny sygnał**~~
7. ~~The manager asked us _____ the tasks that affected customers most. / **ustalić priorytety**~~
8. ~~Starting a new role often involves a steep _____, especially when the systems are unfamiliar. / **krzywa uczenia się**~~
9. ~~By sharing lessons from previous projects, she learned _____. / **przekształcić doświadczenie w autorytet**~~
10. ~~Choosing the faster option may involve a _____ between speed and quality. / **kompromis**~~
11. ~~His technical _____ gave the team confidence during the emergency. / **kompetencje**~~
12. ~~After receiving feedback, the designers decided _____ their original plan. / **ponownie dostosować**~~
13. ~~When the same issue appears in several departments, it may be an _____ rather than a one-off problem. / **wyłaniający się schemat**~~
14. ~~A good adviser must know how _____ around practical benefits. / **sformułować rekomendację**~~

Word Bank

- ~~to recalibrate~~
- ~~confidence gap~~
- ~~professional narrative~~
- ~~trade-off~~
- **to synthesise**
- ~~learning curve~~
- ~~to frame a recommendation~~
- ~~competence~~
- ~~**bottleneck**~~
- ~~to back yourself~~
- ~~early signal~~
- ~~emerging pattern~~
- ~~to turn experience into authority~~
- ~~to prioritise~~

Keyword Revision ? Answer Key

No.	Answer
1	learning curve
2	early signal
3	emerging pattern
4	bottleneck
5	trade-off
6	to synthesise
7	to prioritise
8	to recalibrate
9	competence / confidence gap
10	to back yourself
11	professional narrative
12	to frame a recommendation
13	to turn experience into authority

Teacher note: Sentence 9 deliberately combines *competence* and *confidence gap* to reinforce the contrast from the previous lesson.

The Instant City ? Capitals built from zero

Course: GEN-B2-PLACES | **Lesson:** 01 | **Level:** B2

Topic: planned capitals and purpose-built cities

Lesson aims	Lesson flow
• describe why governments build or relocate capitals; • compare planned cities with cities that grew naturally; • evaluate benefits and drawbacks using balanced B2 language; • use eight place-and-planning keywords accurately in discussion.	1. Previous-lesson keyword retrieval 2. Lead-in and visual prediction 3. Bras?lia, Naypyidaw and Nusantara case studies 4. Vocabulary practice and guided discussion 5. Final recommendation: what makes a planned capital work?

Target language

from scratch ? a master plan ? to relocate ? overcrowded ? to sink ? a landmark ? soulless ? a showcase

Speaking outcome

By the end of the lesson, Aleksandra should be able to give a structured recommendation on whether a country should relocate its capital, supporting her view with examples and clear trade-offs.

Prepared for Aleksandra G?rska ? PVT lesson, 29 July 2026.